An effective transport system is vital to our way of life

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By Phumzile Mahlangu

An effective transport system is vital to our way of life and South Africa is fortunate enough to have modern transport infrastructure. Many people rely on the effectiveness of our transportation to access services such as healthcare, education, going to work and other opportunities. Government is therefore committed to improve the country's infrastructure and to provide the citizens of this country with safe and accessible public transport.

As we mark Transport Month in October, we recognise that an efficient transport network serves as the catalyst to grow our economy and is central to job creation and achieving a better life for all. This month is used to raise awareness on the important role of transport and to showcase major investments on transport infrastructure. Our investments aims to ensure that we build an integrated public transport network across the country.

During this period government showcases the development of transport infrastructure and services across aviation; maritime; public transport and roads to demonstrate the effectiveness of the transport system. The initiative also encourages the public to make greater use of public transport, aiming to reduce traffic congestion and promote responsive road safety behaviour. These efforts are part of a broader strategy to advance national road safety initiatives and raise awareness about the economic and social benefits of the transport sector.

Government's objective is to ensure a safe, reliable and efficient transport system that connects the country and helps to ensure inclusive growth. A vital part of this is working to ensure that the vehicles of Transport operators are roadworthy and safe for the transportation of commuters. Roadworthy vehicles are fundamental to road safety.

An effective transport system is a contributing factor for positioning the country as an attractive investment destination. This includes the use of an integrated transport and road network which is a key factor in attracting investment into the country and the continent.

An efficient transport network, that includes modes such as road, rail, air, and maritime routes, helps to facilitate trade and investment, attracting businesses, and generating employment opportunities, and stimulating economic growth. Our investments in transport networks are helping to open new markets in the African regions and creates a solid platform for intra African trade.

The country's transport infrastructure is modern and among the most developed in Africa. The air and rail networks are the largest on the continent, and the major roads are in good condition. Making the sector a key contributor to the country's competitiveness in global markets.

Our investments in the transport sector are also crucial in addressing challenges such as unemployment, poverty and inequality. These investments are changing the way people access their places of work, study and entertainment. Notable examples include the Gautrain, and the revamped Metro Rail passenger fleet as well as the Gauteng Freeway Improvement Project and the launch of Business Express trains to ease congestion in Gauteng.

Going forward government has set six clear targets outlined by Minister of Transport Barbara Creecy, that are focusing at improving all entities that is the passenger, freight and logistics system in the coming four years.

The first is to ensure that by 2029, 250 million tons of freight are carried on the Transnet network. The second is to improve the speed by which we load and unload ships to the international benchmark of 30 gross crane moves per hour.

The third is to ensure our passenger rail system provides safe, reliable and affordable transport to workers and their families and achieves 600 million passenger journeys per annum by 2030.

To boost the contribution of aviation to tourism, government expects 42 million passengers and 1.2 million tons of air-freight to move through the ACSA network of airports by the end of this political term.
Furthermore, to ensure greater safety on our roads and reduce the devastating toll road accidents have on lives, livelihoods government aim to reduce road fatalities by 45% by 2029 so we reach the UN target of halving road fatalities by 2030.

As we observe transport month, we are reminded that roadworthy vehicles are fundamental to road safety, especially for long-distance travel. Together we can significantly improve road safety, if every road user maintains their vehicles.

Phumzile Mahlangu is Assistant Director: Communication Resource Centre at GCIS

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